The R&AW has become synonymous with the liberation of Bangladesh. Though generations of spies grew up with various versions of how their agency severed East Pakistan from Pakistan and created Bangladesh, nothing was ever confirmed or denied because of the secrecy involved.

But many other exploits and setbacks are cardinal to the lives of Indian spies, some of which even their spouses are not aware of. Many of the stories in this book were scripted when R&AW had just turned adult as an organisation. In 1980s, Indian spies suddenly found themselves in the raging battlefields of Afghanistan. Mikhail Gorbachev had not yet arrived on the scene in the erstwhile USSR but the introduction of Stinger missiles by the USA had changed the Soviet game plan. India feared that the state of the art weapons meant for Afghan mujahideen—the resistance force against the Soviets—were being diverted by Pakistan's intelligence organisation, Inter Service Intelligence (ISI). On another front, in the island nation of Fiji, Sitiveni Rabuka, a Fijian army general and sworn enemy of ethnic Indians, had seized power from the elected Prime Minister Timoci Bavadra. Both the Afghanistan and Fiji fronts were treacherous for the Indian spies. The US did nothing in both the cases. It neither prevented the ISI from siphoning arms and money to raise proxy terror outfits against India, nor mounted pressure on Rabuka to stop the persecution of the Fiji Indians. Far from the diplomatic niceties initiated by the Rajiv Gandhi government, Indian spies tackled overpowering threats in Fiji in ways that do them credit.

For India, these operations anchored the challenges of future complex geopolitical structures in three words: secrecy, speed and success. Indian hunters had begun exerting their influence abroad. Eager agents on the ground effectively engineered